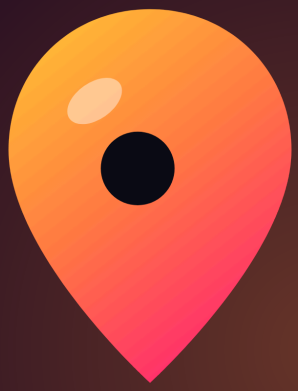
DESIGN ONLY · BUILD PLAN

Lokal

The full plan for designing the app: every mockup so far, brand, design system, every screen, motion, how we design the custom emoji, and launch art.



Version 1 · October 16, 2026

Prepared by the lead designer for the founder

"Lokal" is a placeholder name · Launch: US and Canada, every city at once

1 · OVERVIEW

What this plan covers

This is the design side of the app only: how it looks, moves and feels, and every piece of art it needs. Backend, data and engineering steps are in the separate development plan.

The product in one line

A live, Waze-style map of small, independent food (food trucks, carts, pop-ups, market stalls and small restaurants, no chains), where people share locations, rate spots and talk about them. Owners run their spot from a Business mode in the same app.

Design principles

1. Fun without feeling like a game

Animated emoji pins, moving trucks, emoji rain and celebrations. No mascots, no nagging streak alerts, no Duolingo look. Rewards come from the food scene itself.

2. The map is the app

Everything starts and ends on the map. Sheets slide over it and never replace it. Live things (trucks, reports, drops) move and glow.

3. Night street-food mood

The night map is the hero look: deep navy, warm neon glows, food colors that pop. A day map exists for daylight readability.

4. One tap to contribute

Reporting, checking in, confirming and going live take one or two taps. Owners can run a truck one-handed.

5. Honest and local

"Not a chain" is a visible promise. Reports show how fresh they are. AI answers only use real spots.

6. Works for everyone, everywhere

English and Canadian French, miles or km, screen readers, reduce motion, and quiet areas that still feel alive.

How design work gets done (phone-only)

- **Explore:** clickable HTML mockups and design boards, opened on your phone as private pages.
- **Decide:** you make the call; every decision and change is recorded in `design/DESIGN_LOG.md`.
- **Build:** approved designs go straight into the app's code and theme files.
- **Review:** check in the instant browser preview, then on your phone through a live update.
- **Emoji:** generated in ChatGPT as 3×3 sheets, then split, cleaned and exported automatically.

2 · WHERE DESIGN STANDS

Done, in progress, open

A snapshot as of today.

ITEM	STATUS	NOTES
Visual direction	DONE	Mockup v3 (night street-food look) plus Business mode from v4.
Logo concept	DONE	B · Bite pin: a map pin with a bite taken out of it (food + location).
Colors and wordmark	DONE	Sun, Grill, Chili, Night, Moon. Wordmark in Unbounded ExtraBold.
Animated splash	DONE	3.5 s total: bite, soft recoil, crumbs, wordmark, tagline, slow fade into the app. Live on the phone.
Emoji style anchor	DONE	Glossy 3D sticker, thin white rim, no dark outlines. Taco and burger are the reference.
Custom emoji	METHOD SET	Style anchored, generate-and-clean workflow tested. Full method in section 9.
Final bite shape	DECIDE	Three equal teeth (main) and two big teeth for 24 px and smaller.
App icon background	DECIDE	White pin on the gradient, or gradient pin on Night navy.
Final name	DECIDE	Must work in English and French; trademark search before final art.

3 · MOCKUPS

All mockups so far

Four clickable mockup versions, each one building on the last. All spots, people and numbers in them are fictional sample data (Austin, TX). The final app follows v3 for eaters and v4 for owners.

VERSION	NAME	WHAT IT ADDED, AND WHAT WE KEPT
v1	First playful map	The first take: a bright, friendly map with emoji pins, quests and an owner view. Too close to a cartoon game, but it set the core features.
v2	Illustrated map	Added onboarding, a draggable sheet, the radial report menu, add a spot and an inbox. More polish, still daytime and playful.
v3	Night street-food (chosen direction)	The chosen look: night map with glowing pins, Drops instead of quests, a personal food map, weekly recap. Fun without feeling like a game.
v4	Business mode (chosen for owners)	The v3 eater app plus a full Business mode in the same app. Shown here: the owner screens only (the eater screens match v3).

What carries into the final design

- **From v1–v2:** emoji pins, the radial report menu, the pull-up sheet, the 3-step add a spot, share cards.
- **From v3:** the night look, glowing pins, Drops, the You tab (food map, taste, lists, perks), weekly recap.
- **From v4:** Business mode: claim, go live, where to park, menu and menu scan, promote, insights.
- **Dropped:** quests and points-first rewards (too game-like), the daytime-only look.

Logo and splash boards



A · Pin-o



B · Bite pin (chosen)



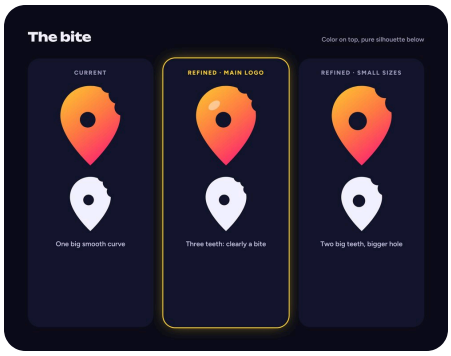
C · Neon sign

3 · MOCKUPS

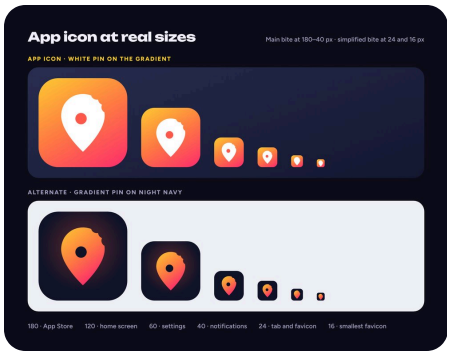
Logo: concepts and the refined bite pin



D · Sticker slap



B refined · the bite



B refined · app icon at real sizes



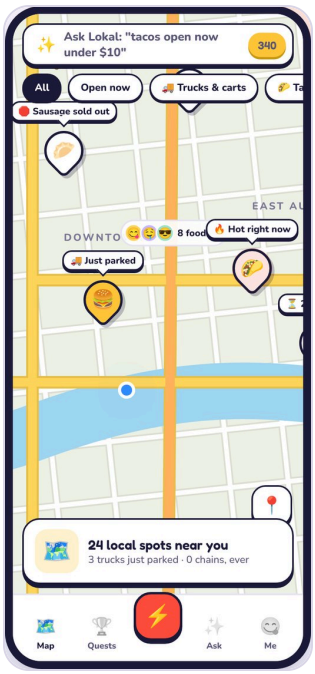
B refined · colors and versions

The animated splash concepts (A–D and the refined B) were explored on the same design canvas. The refined B splash is now built into the app and runs on the phone.

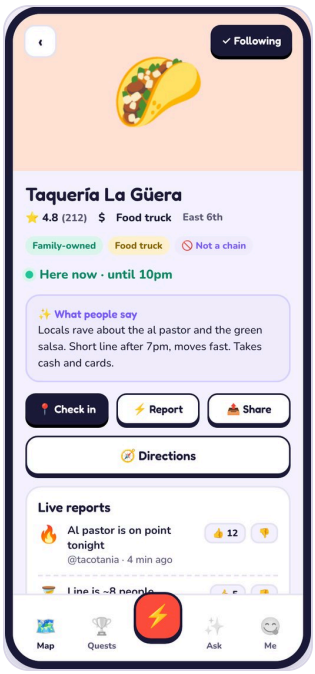
3 · MOCKUPS

Mockup v1: First playful map

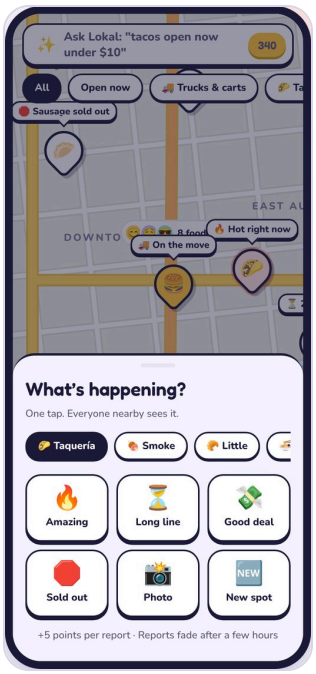
The first take: a bright, friendly map with emoji pins, quests and an owner view. Too close to a cartoon game, but it set the core features.



Map



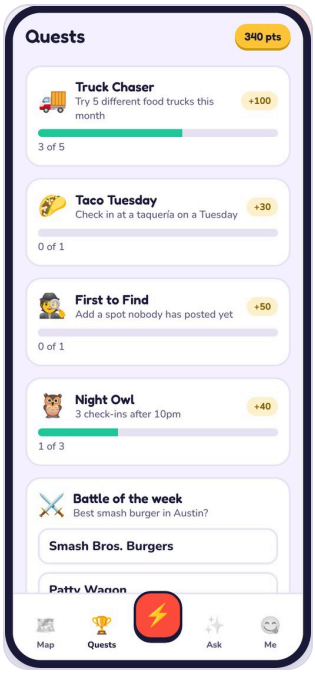
Spot page



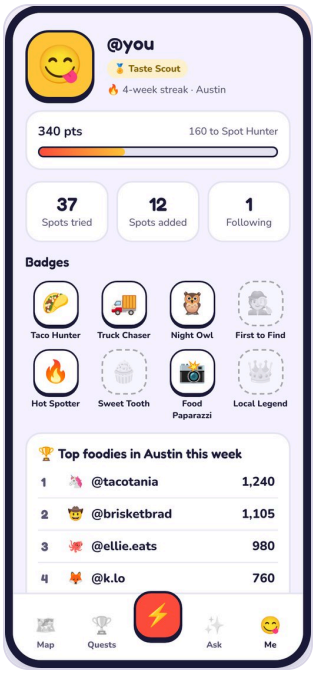
Report menu



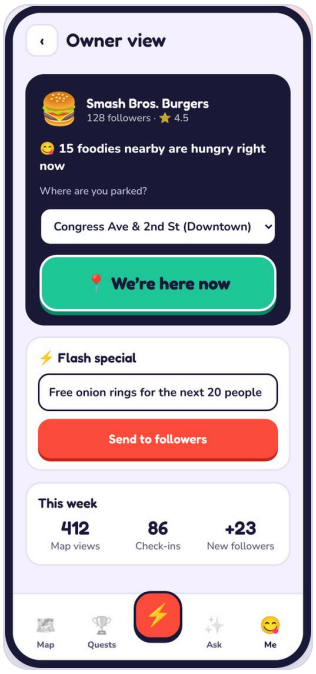
Ask Lokal



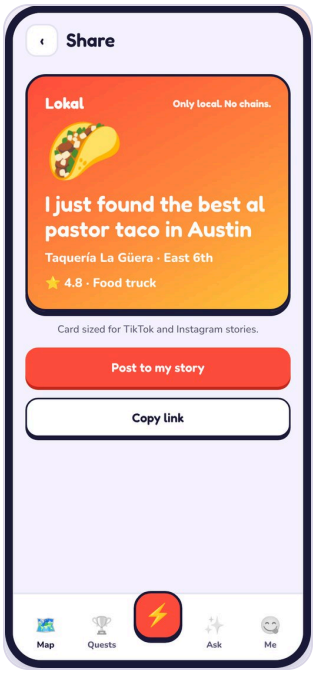
Quests



Profile



Owner view

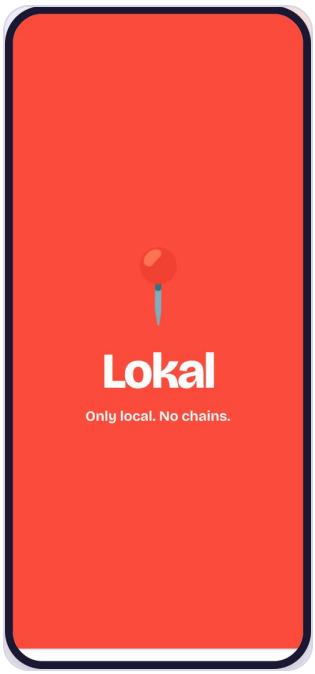


Share card

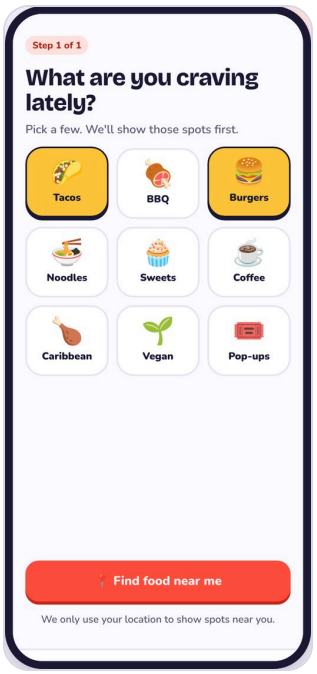
3 · MOCKUPS

Mockup v2: Illustrated map

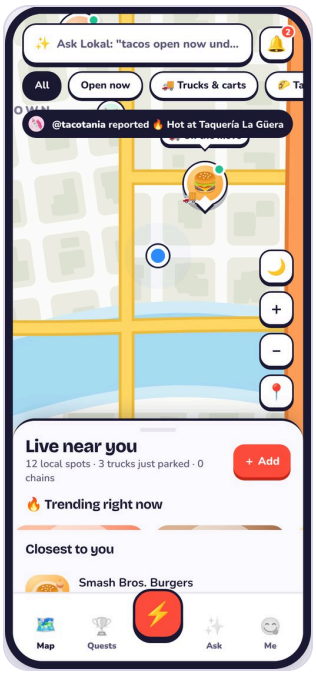
Added onboarding, a draggable sheet, the radial report menu, add a spot and an inbox. More polish, still daytime and playful.



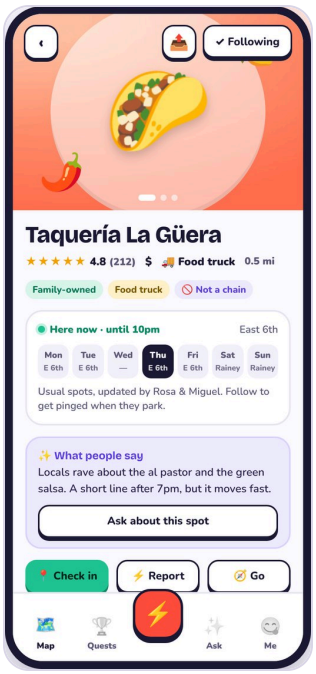
Splash



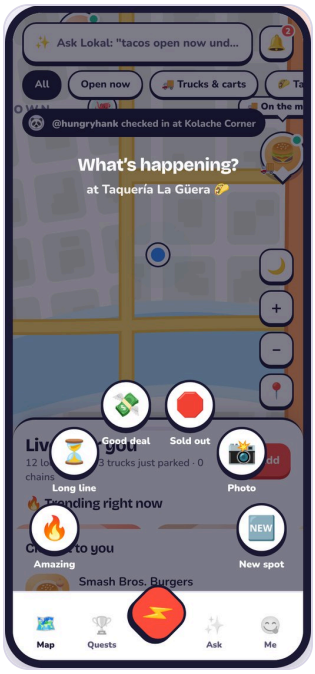
Onboarding



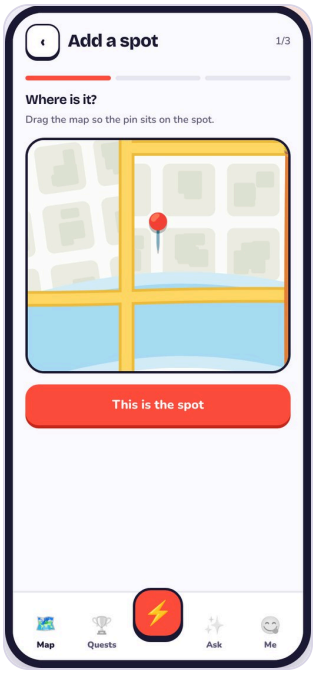
Map



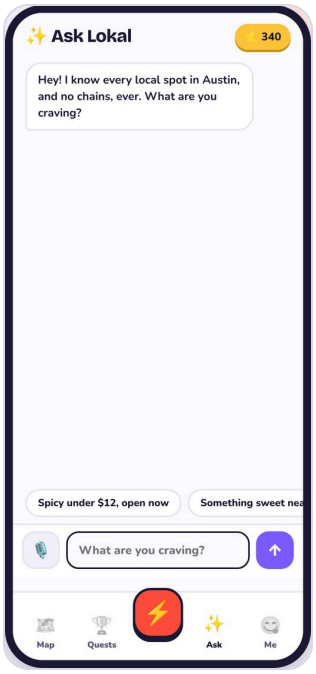
Spot page



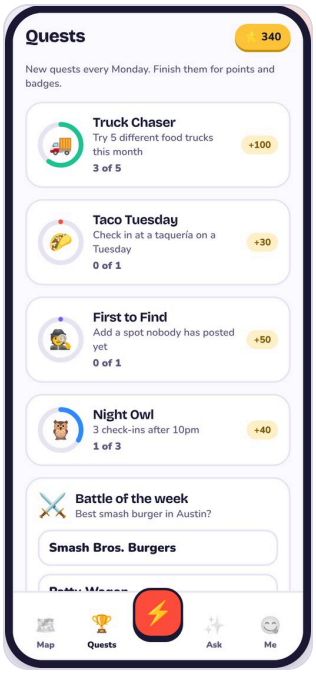
Radial report



Add a spot

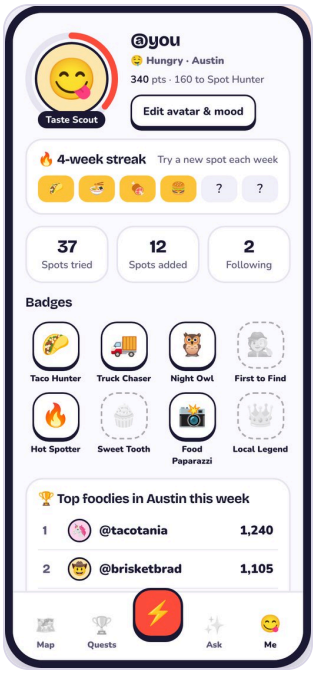


Ask Lokal

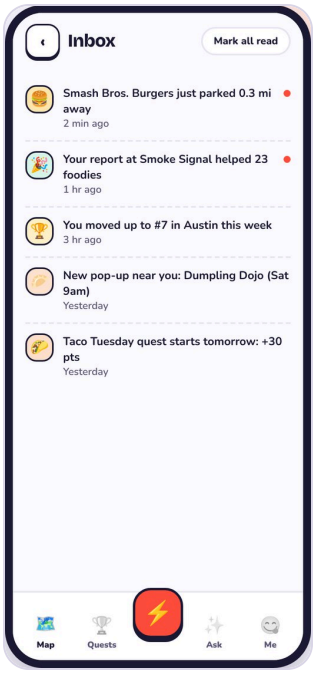


Quests

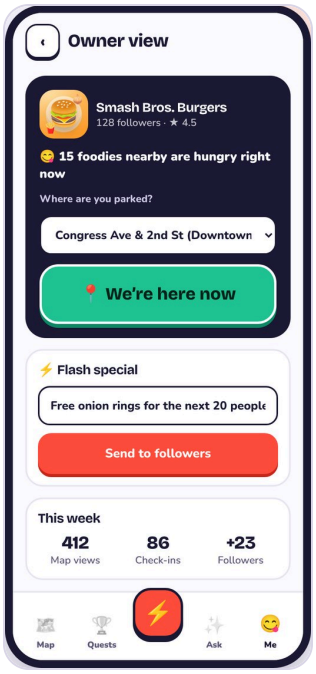
Mockup v2: Illustrated map (continued)



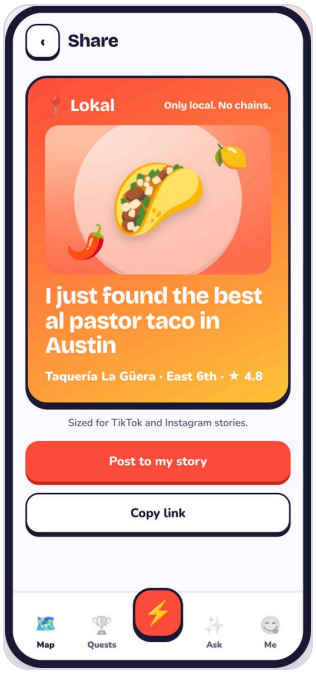
Profile



Inbox



Owner view



Share card

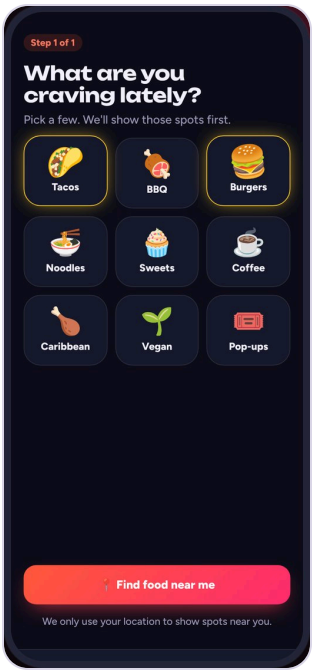
3 · MOCKUPS

Mockup v3: Night street-food (chosen direction)

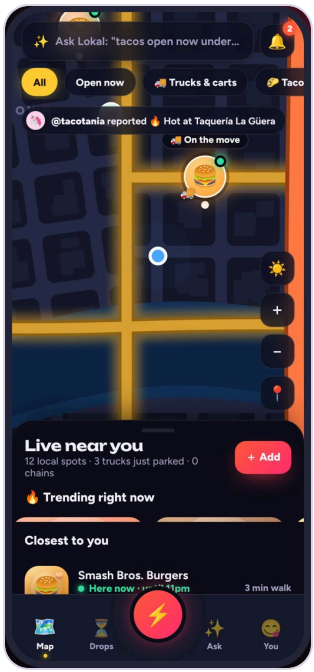
The chosen look: night map with glowing pins, Drops instead of quests, a personal food map, weekly recap. Fun without feeling like a game.



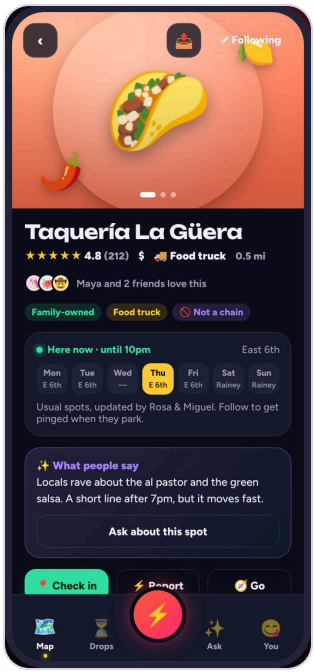
Splash



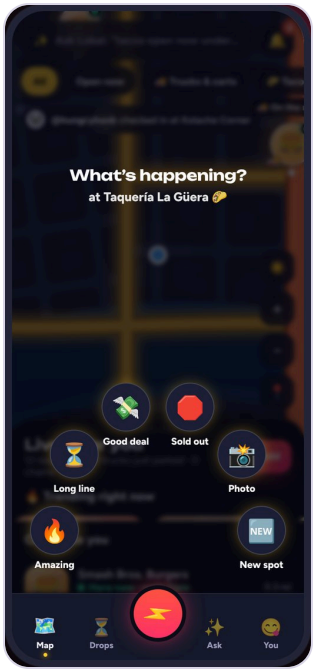
Onboarding



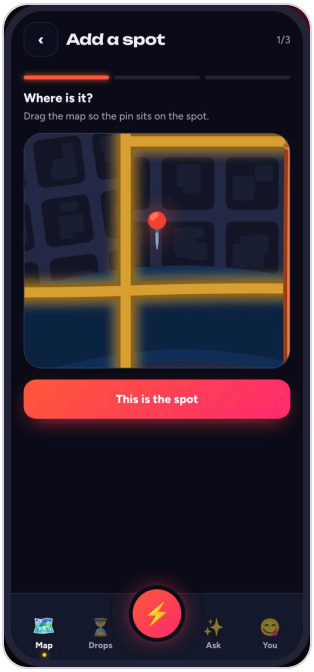
Map



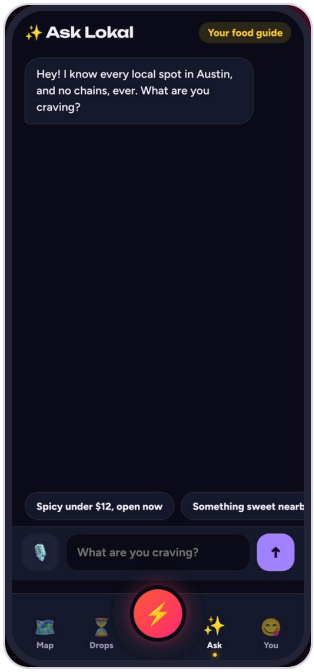
Spot page



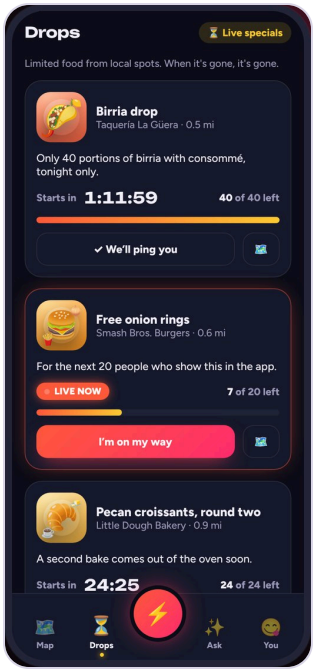
Radial report



Add a spot



Ask Lokal

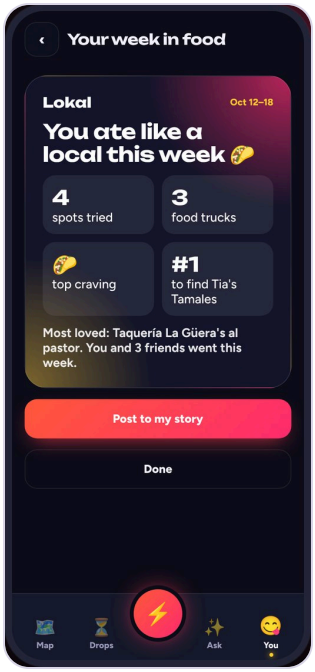


Drops

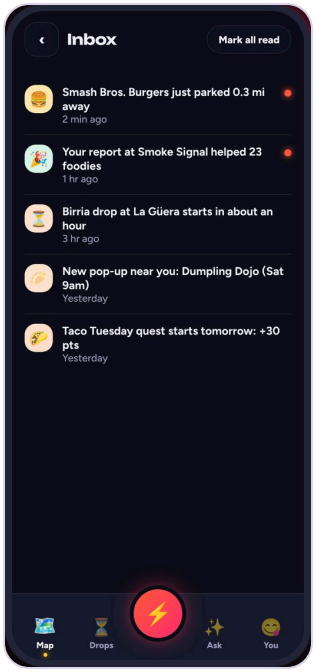
Mockup v3: Night street-food (chosen direction) (continued)



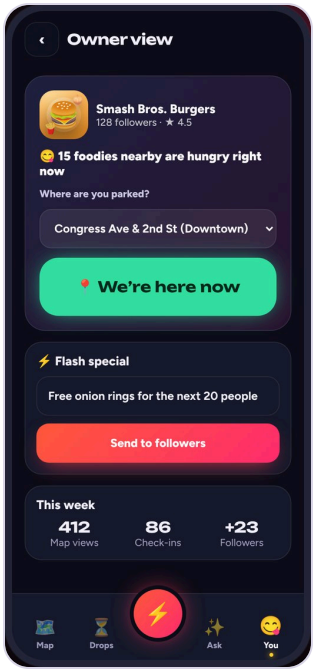
You tab



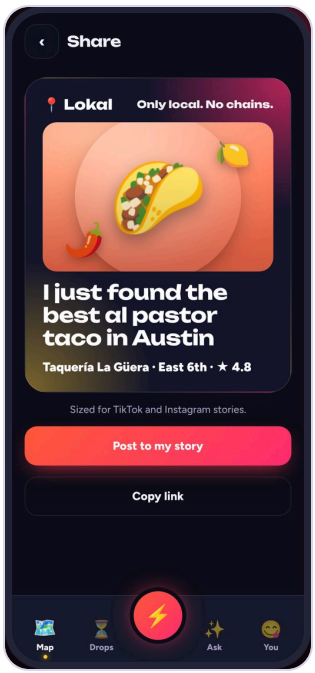
Weekly recap



Inbox



Owner preview

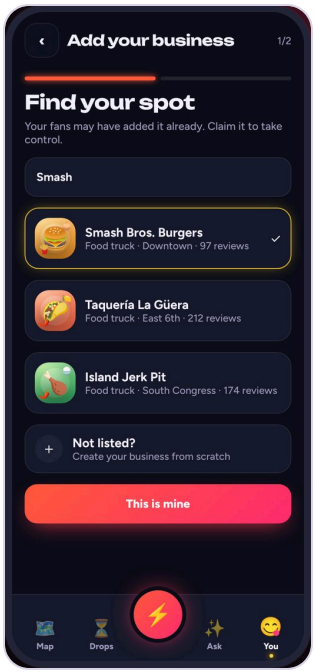


Share card

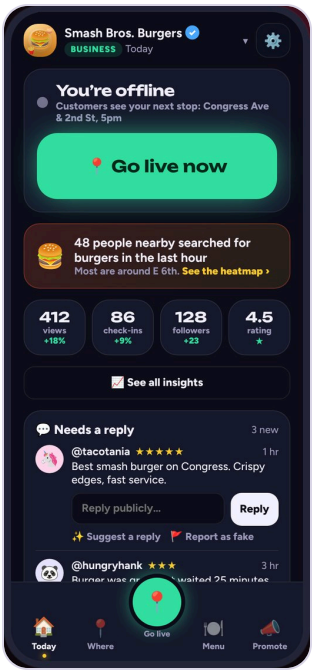
3 · MOCKUPS

Mockup v4: Business mode (chosen for owners)

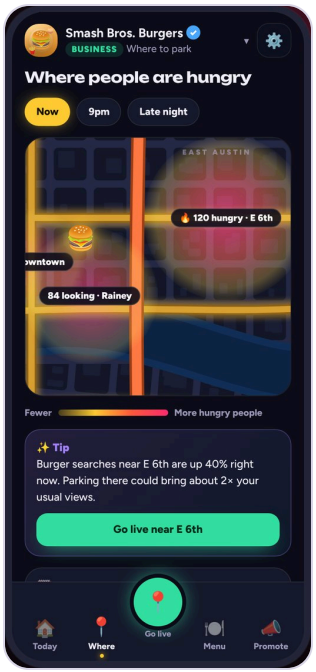
The v3 eater app plus a full Business mode in the same app. Shown here: the owner screens only (the eater screens match v3).



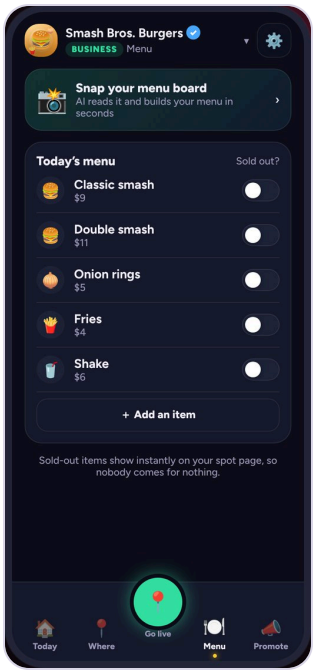
Claim your spot



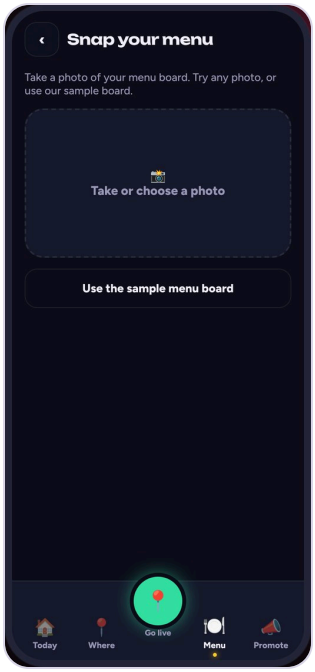
Today (live)



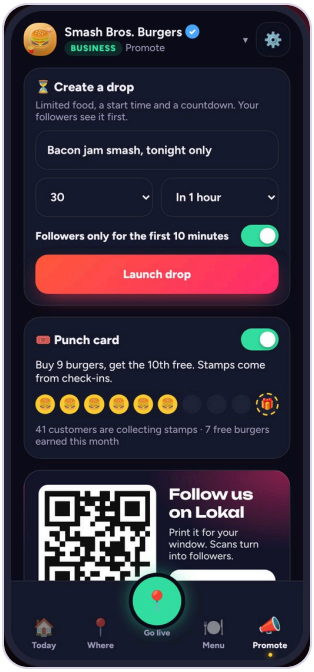
Where to park



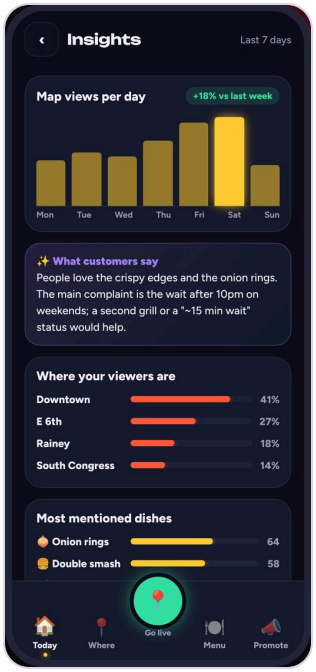
Menu



Snap your menu



Promote



Insights

4 · BRAND

Brand system

The identity every screen and asset is built from.

Colors

Sun
#FFCC33 · highlights, tagline

Grill
#FF7A45 · primary action

Chili
#FF2D6F · live, hot, alerts

Night
#0B0C18 · night background

Moon
#F5F2FF · text on night

The **Sun → Grill → Chili gradient** is the signature. Use it for the logo, the main button, "live" moments and celebrations. Don't use it for body text or large backgrounds.

Logo: Bite pin

- A map pin with three rounded tooth marks at the top right, a night-colored hole, and a pointed tail.
- It must read as a **food bite, not Apple's logo**: always on the pin shape, never on a round fruit-like shape, no leaf.
- Versions: full color (gradient pin), one color white on the gradient, one color dark on light, and a small-size version (two big teeth, bigger hole) for 24 px and smaller.
- Clear space equals the hole's diameter on every side. Minimum size: 16 px.

Type

USE	FONT	NOTES
Wordmark, big titles	Unbounded ExtraBold (800)	Tight letter spacing. Titles only, never paragraphs.
Everything else	Figtree 400 / 600 / 700 / 800	Friendly and very readable at small sizes. Both fonts are free Google Fonts (OFL).

Voice

- Short, warm, a bit playful: "Just parked", "Sold out, sorry!", "Be the first to find one here".
- Talk like a local friend, not a brand. No guilt-tripping and no fake urgency.
- Tagline (draft): **"Only local. No chains."**
- Every line is written in English and Canadian French. French runs about 20% longer, so layouts must leave room.

5 · DESIGN SYSTEM

Tokens and components

These are proposals. They're set once in the app's theme file, and every screen uses them, so a change in one place updates the whole app.

Color roles

ROLE	NIGHT THEME	DAY THEME	USE
Background	#0B0C18	#FFFAF3	Screens, behind the map
Surface	#161829	#FFFFFF	Sheets, cards
Surface raised	#20233A	#F4F0FA	Chips, inputs, pressed states
Text	#F5F2FF	#17162A	Main text
Text muted	#A7A3C2	#5D5A75	Secondary text, timestamps
Primary	Grill #FF7A45, or the gradient on main buttons		Main actions
Live / open	Green #3DDC84 with a pulsing dot		Open now, live trucks
Hot / alert	Chili #FF2D6F		Trending, sold out, drops ending

All text and background pairs must pass WCAG AA contrast (4.5:1 for body text).

Type scale (Figtree unless noted)

- Display 32: Unbounded 800
- Title 24: Unbounded 800
- Heading 18: 800
- Body 16: 500
- Label 14: 700
- Caption 12: 600

Spacing, shape, touch

- 4-point grid: 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32
- Corner radius: 12 (chips), 18 (cards), 28 (sheets), round (pins, avatars)
- Minimum touch target: 48 × 48
- Screen side margin: 16
- Shadows only on the day theme; glows on the night theme

Core components

COMPONENT	WHAT IT INCLUDES
Map pin	Emoji sticker, glow (night) or shadow (day), anchor dot, spot-type badge chip, live dot, "hot" state, cluster bubble
Bottom sheet	Three heights (peek, half, full), grab handle, swipe down to close
Buttons	Gradient primary, outline secondary, ghost, icon button, the floating report button
Chips	Filter chips (with emoji), status chips (Open, Live, Sold out, Closing soon)
Cards	Spot card, drop card with countdown, report card, review card, insight card
Radial menu	The report arc: 6 emoji options fanning out from the button
Inputs	Search bar, text field, phone code input, photo picker, time picker ("serving until")
Feedback	Toasts, emoji celebration, empty state, skeleton loader, error state, offline banner
Navigation	Tab bar with a center action, top bar, segmented control, eater/business switch
Avatar	Foodie avatar with a mood badge and rep ring
Utility icons	One standard set (Phosphor or Lucide) for back, share, settings; custom emoji only where they carry meaning

6 · THE MAP

Map design spec

The map is the most important piece of design in the app.

Night map (hero)

- Deep navy land and water, muted gray-blue streets.
- Few labels: only neighborhoods and major streets.
- Pins glow in each food's own glow color.
- Turns on at sunset automatically, or by user choice.

Day map

- Warm off-white land, soft streets and parks.
- Pins sit on a soft drop shadow instead of a glow.
- Same layout and labels as the night map.

Pins

- **The sticker is the pin:** no colored circle behind it. There's a small anchor dot under it.
- **Spot-type badge** (truck, cart, trailer, pop-up, stall, restaurant, bike cart) on a small round chip at the bottom-left. The chip is white on the day map and dark navy on the night map.
- **States:** open, closed (faded), live (pulsing dot), hot (sparks), new, sold out.
- **Sizes:** 40 px default, 56 px selected or hot, 24 px when zoomed out.
- **Clusters:** when zoomed out, pins merge into a bubble showing the top emoji and a count.
- **Moving trucks:** slide smoothly along the street to their new spot. They never jump.

Quiet areas (every city at launch)

Many places will have restaurants from seed data but no trucks reported yet. These areas should feel inviting, not empty:

- Seeded restaurants and stalls always show, so the map is never blank.
- A "No trucks reported here yet. Be the first!" card with an add-a-spot button.
- An invite-a-truck link to share with a favorite vendor.
- A "first to find" badge for whoever adds the first truck in an area.

On the map screen

- **Top:** search and a row of filter chips: Open now, Trucks and carts, Cuisine, Pop-ups, Cheap eats.
- **Bottom sheet:** "Live near you", with Trending right now and Closest to you.
- **Floating buttons:** report, and recenter on me.

7 · SCREENS

Screen inventory: eaters

Every screen to design for version 1. Most already exist as rough versions in mockups v3 and v4. Each needs a final design, a day and night version, French text, and empty, loading and error states.

Main tabs: Map · Drops · *Report (center)* · Ask · You

AREA	SCREENS
First launch	Animated splash DONE · welcome · "What are you craving lately?" taste picker · location permission (explains why) · notifications permission · choose your foodie avatar and mood
Sign in	Sign in with Apple, Google, or phone · "Quick check that it's you" code screen · browse without an account, with a sign-in prompt when someone tries to contribute
Map	Map home (night and day) · search and results · filters · Live near you sheet · cluster zoom · quiet-area card · offline banner
Spot page	Photos · live status and "serving until" · weekly schedule · busy times · top dishes · "What people say" AI summary · live reports · reviews · "Not a chain" badge · follow, directions, share, check in
Contribute	Report radial menu ("What's happening?") · confirm or reject a report ("Still true?") · check-in celebration · write a review · add a spot in 3 steps (Where is it? / What is it? / Add a photo) · chain-blocked message
Drops	Drops list with countdowns · drop detail and claim · reminder set · event page (e.g. a food truck rally)
Ask Lokal	Chat with suggested questions · answers shown as spot cards · daily limit reached
You	Profile and rep · your food map · your taste profile · lists · friends lately · insider perks · weekly recap and share card
Inbox	Notifications: a followed truck parked nearby, a drop starting, replies to you
Share	Share card for a spot ("I just found the best… in [city]") and for the weekly recap (story and post sizes)
Settings	Language (English, French) · units (miles or km) · night or day map · notifications and quiet hours · privacy, export my data, delete account · help and report a problem

7 · SCREENS

Screen inventory: Business mode

The same app, switched to Business. It must be usable with one hand, at a busy window, in bright sun, so it gets high contrast, big buttons and the day theme by default.

Business tabs (from mockup v4): Today · Where · *Go live (center)* · Menu · Promote. Insights and review replies open from Today.

AREA	SCREENS
Get started	"Own a food truck or small spot?" entry on You · "Find your spot" search · claim and verify (phone code + photo) · "Add your business" if it's not listed · switch between eater and business
Go live	"Where are you serving?" (map pin drag) · serving until · "You're live" or "You're offline" · one-tap statuses: wait time, closing soon, sold out, closed
Schedule	Your weekly stops (repeat days, times, places)
Menu	Today's menu with sold-out toggles · edit an item (name, price, emoji) · "Snap your menu" camera · AI scan results ("Found 12 items") to review
Promote	Create a drop (special, quantity, start time, followers first) · flash special · message your followers (3 per week)
Reviews	"Needs a reply" list · reply to a review · report a fake review
Insights	Map views per day · check-ins · followers · busy hours · where your viewers are · most mentioned dishes
Grow	Link-in-bio page · QR poster ("Follow us on Lokal") to print · business settings

Not in version 1 (designed later): "Where people are hungry" heatmap, punch cards, Lokal Pro, team accounts, multiple trucks, order ahead and payments. Keep space for them in the navigation, but don't design the details yet.

8 · MOTION

Motion and interaction

Motion is where the fun lives. It should be soft and smooth, never snappy or bouncy, the same way we tuned the splash.

SPEED	DURATION	USED FOR
Quick	150–200 ms	Taps, toggles, chip selection
Standard	250–350 ms	Sheets, screens, cards appearing
Expressive	500–900 ms	Celebrations, splash, going live, emoji rain

Default easing is the soft curve from the splash (cubic-bezier 0.45, 0, 0.25, 1), with no overshoot on important actions.

Signature moments

- **Pins:** a gentle bob; sparks on hot spots; trucks slide to new spots.
- **Report:** the arc fans out; the chosen emoji floats up from the pin.
- **Check-in:** food emoji rain plus a short "nice find" message.
- **Go live (owner):** a pulse ring spreads from the pin across the map.
- **Drop:** a ticking countdown; a burst when it starts.
- **First to find:** a detective reveal when someone adds the first spot in an area.
- **Haptics:** a light tap on report, check-in and going live (phones that support it).
- **Sounds:** optional and later; always off when the phone is silent.

> **Reduce motion:** when it's on in the phone's settings, celebrations become a simple fade, pins stop bobbing, and trucks move without the slide. Every meaning still comes through without the animation.

9 · CUSTOM EMOJI

How we design the custom emoji

Every emoji in the app is our own: the same on iPhone, Android and the web, and part of the brand. This is the method every set goes through, from the first idea to the file in the app.

The style rules (the "anchor")

- **Look:** glossy, soft 3D sticker, like a premium emoji set. Never photoreal, flat or painted.
- **Shapes:** chunky, rounded and simple, with only a few details. It must read clearly at 24 px.
- **Light:** always from the top left, with one clear highlight per main shape and a small soft shadow at the bottom right.
- **Rim:** a thin, even white outline around the whole shape, like a die-cut sticker. No dark outline lines inside it.
- **Solid:** fully opaque, with no haze, glow or see-through parts. The app adds the glow.
- **No text** inside any emoji, so nothing needs translating.
- **Reference:** every new emoji is judged next to the two approved anchor emoji.

The 7 steps

#	STEP	WHO	WHAT HAPPENS
1	Brief	Lead designer	Choose the next set from the plan. For each item, define what it must say at a glance ("sold out" = clearly stopped, not just sad), what it must not look like (e.g. curry must not look like ramen), and its glow color.
2	Prompt	Lead designer	Write one ready-to-paste prompt per 3×3 sheet: the 9 items in order, the style rules word for word, the layout (spaced grid, transparent background) and the "match the anchors" instruction.
3	Generate	Founder, in ChatGPT	Upload the two anchor images, paste the prompt, and keep working in the same chat so the style stays consistent. Make 2–3 tries if needed and send back the best sheet.
4	Split and clean	Automatic tool	Splits the sheet into 9 files. Removes the background haze, makes every pixel solid, separates touching emoji, keeps detached bits (like raindrops) with their emoji, then trims and centers on a square.
5	Review	Lead designer, then founder	Side by side with the anchors. Then at 24, 40 and 56 px on the night and day maps, and in real use: on a pin, on a badge chip, in a list and in chat.
6	Approve or redo	Founder decides	Each emoji is approved, or sent back with a specific note ("simpler, bigger wheels"). Redo emoji go into a focused re-prompt. Every verdict is logged in the design log.
7	Export and connect	Lead designer	Exported at 3 sizes (1x, 2x, 3x) with consistent names. Each is added to the emoji list file with its glow color and search words, and the app picks it up with no code change.

Prompt pattern and quality checks

The sheet prompt pattern

```
Create an emoji sprite sheet for a food app's custom emoji set.
Order (left to right, top to bottom): 1. [item] … 9. [item]

Style (the same for all 9): match the exact style of the two images I uploaded. Stylized 3D
emoji illustration, NOT photorealistic. Smooth, glossy surfaces, soft gradients, one clear
highlight per main shape. Simple, chunky, rounded shapes that read at 40 px. Soft light from
the top left, small soft shadow at the bottom right. A thin, even white outline like a die-cut
sticker. Fully solid, no glow or haze. No dark outline lines.

Layout: a 3×3 grid on one square image, each icon centered in its cell, filling about 75% of
it, with clear space between icons.
Background: fully transparent. No text, numbers, labels, grid lines or scenery.
```

Only the item list changes between sheets. Each item is described by its shape and one or two key details, never by a brand.

Quality checklist (every emoji, before approval)

Style

- Same glossiness, color strength and rim thickness as the anchors.
- No dark outlines, no painted texture, no photo look.
- Fully solid after cleaning, with no halo.

Readability

- Recognizable at 24 px without its label.
- Doesn't look like another emoji in the set.
- Works on both the night and day maps.

In context

- As a map pin with its glow.
- As a small badge on the round chip.
- Next to text in lists, chat and buttons.

Safe to ship

- No resemblance to real brands, logos or characters.
- No text or letters.
- Clear rights to use the image commercially.

Rules that keep the set consistent

- **One set at a time,** each made just before the design phase that needs it.
- **Placeholders first:** the app is built with stand-in emoji, so design and code never wait on art. Swapping in the final emoji only means replacing files.
- **Same chat, same anchors:** every sheet starts from the two approved anchor images.
- **Simplify for small sizes:** badges and status icons get fewer details than food.
- **The human pass:** the app icon and logo get redrawn by a designer before trademarking. AI-only art can't be reliably protected, and the same option stays open for the emoji later.

Accessibility and two languages

Accessibility

- Every pin, emoji and button has a screen reader label (e.g. "Taco truck, open, 0.3 miles").
- Contrast passes WCAG AA on both maps.
- Status is never shown by color alone: there's always an icon or a word too.
- Text grows with the phone's settings without breaking layouts.
- Reduce motion is respected everywhere.
- A list view of nearby spots as an alternative to the map.

English and Canadian French

- Every screen is designed with French text at the same time, not after.
- Leave about 20% extra room: no fixed-width buttons and no text in images.
- Miles or km and USD or CAD follow the region.
- Times show in each spot's local time zone.
- French reviewed by a native Canadian French speaker.
- The final name must work in both languages.

States every screen needs

STATE	DESIGN
Loading	Skeleton shapes in the surface color with a soft shimmer (no spinners on main screens)
Empty	A friendly emoji, one line of text, and one clear action
Error	Plain words about what happened, plus Try again
Offline	A banner; the last viewed area stays usable from the cache
No permission	Explains why location helps, and still lets you browse by searching a city

Design build phases

Each phase is designed one step ahead of the code, so the app is never waiting on design. Every phase ends with something you approve on your phone.

D1 Foundations

Week 1

- Approve the final bite shape and app icon, then export the icon in every size.
- Lock the color roles, type scale, spacing and radius tokens in the app's theme file.
- Design the core components (buttons, chips, cards, sheets, tab bar) in night and day.
- Set up translation-ready text, and the screen-state patterns (loading, empty, error).

Done when: a component sample screen in the app looks right in both themes and in French.

D2 The map

Weeks 1–2

- Custom Mapbox night and day styles in brand colors.
- Sticker pins, glow and shadow, badge chips, live dot, hot state, clusters.
- Search and filter chips, the "Live near you" sheet, and the quiet-area card.
- Redo the spot-type badges (needed on every pin).

Done when: real spots look great on the night map on your phone, zoomed in and out.

D3 Spot page and contributing

Weeks 2–3

- Final spot page.
- Report radial menu, check-in, add a spot, and reviews.
- First launch: onboarding, permissions, sign-in, avatar and mood.
- Live report and status emoji sheets; reactions.

Done when: you can go from opening the app to checking in, and it feels smooth and fun.

D4 Business mode

Weeks 3–5

- Claim and verify, go live, statuses, and weekly stops.
- Menu and menu scan, drops, follower messages, review replies, insights.
- Business tools emoji, the QR poster and the link-in-bio page.
- Test one-handed use in bright light.

Done when: you can run a test truck from your phone in under 30 seconds a day.

D5 Ask Lokal, Drops, Inbox, You

Weeks 5–6

- Ask Lokal chat and answer cards.
- Drops list and detail, events, and the inbox.
- The You tab: food map, taste profile, lists, perks, the weekly recap and share cards.
- Avatar, reward and drop emoji sheets.

Done when: every tab in the app is designed and built.

D6 The fun layer and polish

Weeks 6–8

- All signature animations and haptics.
- Remaining food emoji (sheets 2–4) and celebrations.
- Full accessibility pass, French review, and a check of every empty, error and offline state.

Done when: the app on your phone feels like the v3/v4 mockups, or better.

D7 Launch art

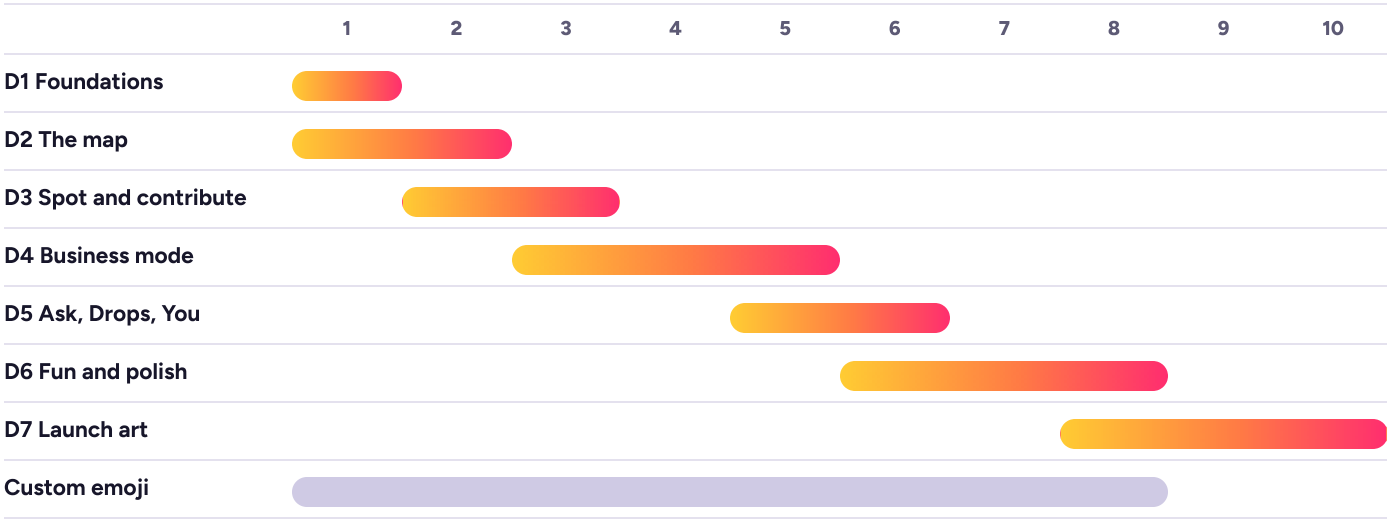
Weeks 8–10

- Final name.
- Trademark search, then the designer-redrawn logo; update the splash and icon.
- Store screenshots and preview video in English and French.
- Feature graphic, landing page look, and social templates.

Done when: both store listings are complete and approved.

Timeline at a glance

Ten weeks, running alongside the development phases. Custom emoji are made in parallel the whole time, each set just before the phase that needs it.



12 · NEXT

Decisions and who does what

Decisions needed from you

DECISION	NEEDED BY	OPTIONS
Final bite shape	D1	Three equal teeth (recommended) or rounded teeth
App icon background	D1	White pin on the gradient (recommended, stands out on home screens) or gradient pin on Night navy
Business tab layout	D4	Keep the v4 tabs (Today · Where · Go live · Menu · Promote) or move Insights into its own tab
Final name	D7	Candidates: Lokal, Dibs, Foodar, Curbie, Nearbite, Tastemap, Glow, Morsel (must work in English and French)

Who does what

You (founder)

- Make the design calls above.
- Review each phase on your phone.
- Generate the emoji sheets in ChatGPT with the prompts I give you, and send them back.
- Find a Canadian French reviewer and, later, a designer for the final logo.

Lead designer (me)

- Design every screen, state and animation in this plan.
- Build the designs into the app and send you previews.
- Write the emoji prompts, then split, clean, check and export the sheets.
- Keep the design log up to date with every decision and change.

Changes already on the list

- Replace circle pins with sticker pins (glow by night, shadow by day, anchor dot).
- Add the round chip behind spot-type badges.
- Load all emoji from `manifest.json` with a glow color per food.
- Put the approved emoji into the mockup to review them on the real map.
- Test the app icon at 16, 24, 40 and 60 px; make a small-size version.
- Make the one-color logo versions.

Related files in the repo: `design/DESIGN_LOG.md` (decisions and changes), `design/ASSETS.md` (emoji specs), `design/EMOJI_PROMPTS.md` (sheet prompts), `DEVELOPMENT_PLAN.md` (engineering). All durations are estimates.